Vishavara, Ghosha and Apala were also prominent seers.) Adi Shankara, in a theological debate with his famous critic Madana Mishra, appointed as the judge between them the latter's learned wife Sarasavani. Even Manu declared, 'where women are honoured, there the gods rejoice, but where they are not honoured, there all rituals are useless.' Of the 210 Shiva-worshipping Lingayat saints, thirty-five are women. In other words, there is authority for different approaches in the ancient texts; the Hindu is invited to take his pick. If the Hindu chooses wrongly, or unwisely, among the opinions offered to him, it is not Hinduism's fault.

The Hindu understands that all scripture requires interpretation, and cannot be taken literally. In particular, there has long been an acknowledgement that what is laid down in ancient texts may not necessarily have been what was, or is, practised in the faith. The strong position held by the polyandrous, property-owning Nair women in Kerala's matrilineal society, the honoured position of Rajput women, who killed themselves en masse after their husbands fell on the battlefield, and the reverence accorded to women mystics like Mirabai and social reformers like Savitribai Phule, show Hinduism as accepting of women as figures of authority and respect. The fact that the *Manusmriti* is both misogynist and casteist does not preclude the possibility that throughout the ages, it was honoured in the breach.

Hinduism offers the believer much to choose from: what you choose to follow is your Hinduism, while others might find scriptural justification for a contrary view. Hindu philosophy testifies to the extent to which reasoned debate amongst the believers—in dialogue with but not restrictively bound by their scriptures—has allowed Hindu religious philosophers throughout history to reform themselves and their faith.

MANY SACRED BOOKS

As I have asserted, Hinduism has not one sacred book, but several, both complementary and contradictory to each other. The Hindu scriptures are commonly divided into Srutis, Smritis, Itihasas, Puranas, Agamas and Darshanas.

The Srutis are that which has been heard or revealed. The four *Vedas —Rig Veda, Sama Veda, Yajur Veda* and *Atharva Veda*—are Sruti, having